Field Guide to Release Notes

Release notes are read by people in a hurry. This guide collects the patterns that make them easier to scan, with an example of each.

Structure

Lists inside lists

1. Summarize the release in one sentence.
2. Group the changes by audience:
    - Users
        - New features
        - Changed behavior
    - Administrators
        - Configuration keys
        - Migration steps
3. Link to the full changelog.

Continuing a numbered list

5. Mark breaking changes clearly.
6. Give the date and the version number.
7. Thank the contributors by name.

Emphasis that carries meaning

Use **bold** for the name of a setting, *italics* for a term defined in the text, and ***both*** only for warnings. A removed option can be shown as legacy_mode with a note on its replacement. Keep `inline code` for values a reader can copy.

Quoting users

> The new export button saved our team an hour every week.
>
> > We still miss the old shortcut, though.
>
> — Customer feedback, March

Long references

Readers often need the exact address of a document, such as https://docs.example.com/releases/2026/october/notes-for-administrators-and-integrators.html, so print it in full even when it wraps.

A wide table

Version	Date	Kind	Highlights	Breaking
4.2.0	2026-10-01	Minor	Export to Parquet, faster search	No
4.1.3	2026-09-12	Patch	Fix for time zones in reports	No
4.0.0	2026-08-01	Major	New permission model, API v3	Yes

Checklist before publishing

- Spell-check the text
- Verify every link
- Ask support to review the wording
- Schedule the announcement

Small print

Notes for previous versions stay online for two years.